

Session 14: Jacob's Lost Sons

Key Takeaways

- Reuven laments that their brother's blood is required of them, activating a pattern of innocent blood crying out to God for justice that stretches all the way back to Cain and Abel in Genesis 4.
- Yoseph's translator is called a "mediator," the same word used to describe the prophets who stand in the gap and intercede between God and Israel.
- The Bible presents a realistic portrait of the human condition, and characters who seem simple at first glance have layers of complexity and insight.

The Brothers' Confession

²¹ And each man said to his brother,
"Oh no! **We are guilty** concerning **our brother**,
when we saw the **distress** (צרה) of his very being, when he pleaded for favor from us,
and **we didn't listen**!
For this reason, this distress (צרה) **has come upon us!**"

²² And Reuven answered them saying,
"Didn't I speak to you, saying,
'Don't **sin** against the boy!'
But **y'all didn't listen**,
and now look, **his blood is required!**"

²³ Now, they did not know that **Yoseph was listening**,
because there was a mediator between them,
²⁴ and he turned away from them and wept,
and **he returned** to them,
and **he spoke** to them,
and he took **Shim'on** from them,
and he **bound him up** before their eyes.

²⁵ **And Yoseph commanded**
that they should fill their **bags** with **grain**,
and **to return** their **silver**, each in his **sack**,

and to give them **rations** (צֹדֶה) for the road.

And so it was done for them .

26 And they took up their **grain** onto their donkeys,
and they went from there,

27 and **one** opened up his **sack**, to give fodder to his donkey at the night-stop,
and he saw his **silver**,
and look, it was in the mouth of his **bag** .

28 And he said **to his brothers**,

“My **silver** has been **returned** ,
and look, its it my **bag** !”

And their hearts went out,

and they shuddered, **each man to his brother, saying** ,

“ **What is this that Elohim is doing to us?! ”**

Genesis 42:21-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

After Yoseph recreates the scenario of Genesis 37 by imprisoning Shimon as a test (recall that this test is set on analogy to the snake and the test of Adam and Eve), his brothers begin processing the poetic justice of their situation. And they do so in speeches filled with the language of the Cain and Abel story from Genesis 4.

Genesis 42	Genesis 4
Gen. 42:21 “We are guilty concerning our brother”	Gen. 4:13 “My guilt/punishment is too great to bear!”
Gen. 42:22 “Didn’t I say, ‘Don’t sin against the boy?’”	Gen. 4:7 “If you don’t do good, sin is crouching at the door; it’s desire is for you, and you can rule it.”
Gen. 42:22 “Now look, his blood is required”	Gen. 4:10 “The voice of your brother’s blood is crying to me from the ground.”
Gen. 42:28 “What is Elohim doing to us?!”	Gen. 4:10 “What is this you have done?!”
Comparing Genesis 42 and Genesis 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Just as God confronted Cain after murdering his brother, now Yoseph confronts his brothers after they sold him as a slave and pretended that he was murdered. This scene of Yoseph bringing his brothers' sin to light is clearly being linked to God’s confrontation with Cain to bring his murderous sin to light.

III-Gotten Silver

The narrative focuses on the silver found in the mouth of the camel bags. This seems to be an intentional parallel to the “20 shekels of silver” that the brothers received by selling Yoseph as a slave headed for Egypt (recall Gen. 37:27-28). Now the brothers are in Egypt, and though a brother was imprisoned, they now also have their money back!

Yoseph here recreates the circumstances of his slavery sale down to the last detail. The brothers now have extra money and plenty of food for a time, the only cost is their brother. Will the brothers go back and lie to Yaaqov again, as they did about Yoseph, or will they choose differently?

The Brothers Return to Yaaqov

Report of Yoseph’s Speech

- 29 And they came to Ya’akov **their father** **in the land of Cana’an** ,
A and they told him **everything that happened** to them, saying,
30 “ **The man, the master of the land, spoke** harsh things **to us** ,
and he took us to be like **spies** of the land!

Report of Brothers’ Speech

- 31 **And we said to him** ,
‘We are **upright** !
B We are not **spies** !
32 We are **two and ten brothers, sons of our father** .
One is no more ,
and the **little one** is with **our father** today, **in the land of Cana’an** .’

Report of Yoseph’s Speech

- 33 **And the man, the master of the land, said to us** ,
‘**By this I will know that y’all are upright** :
Your **one brother** , make him rest here with me,
A’ and the famine-ration for your houses, take and go!
34 And bring to me **your little brother** ,
so I can know that y’all are not spies, that y’all are upright !
I will give **your brother** to you,
then you may trade in the land.”

35 And it came about, as they were emptying their **sacks** ,
that look, each had a **pouch of silver** in his **sack** ,
and they saw the **pouches of silver** , they and their father,
and they became afraid.

Ya'akov's Speech

36 **And their father Ya'akov said to them,**
"Y'all have bereaved me!
A **Yoseph is no more !**
Shim'on is no more!
And you would take **Binyamin ?!**
These things always come upon me !"

Reuven's Speech

37 And **Reuven** said to **their father** , saying,
B "Put **my two sons** to death,
if I do not return him to you!
Give him into my hand,
and I will return him to you!"

Ya'akov's Speech

38 **And he said,**
" **My son** will not **go down** with y'all,
A' **because his brother is dead** ,
and he alone is the remnant,
and **should disaster happen to him** on the road you go upon,
then you would make my gray-hair **go down** to the grave in grief."

Genesis 42:29-38. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yaaqov's Many Lost Sons

Notice how Yaaqov sees a disastrous pattern at work in his life. He compares the past loss of Yoseph to the present loss of Shimon. And now both are compared to the potential loss of Binyamin in the future.

Also recall how Yaaqov's lost sons were earlier compared to Yehudah's two lost sons, Er and Onan, who both died at the beginning of Genesis 38. The loss of those two sons was restored by the birth of the twins from Tamar, the disguised deceiver whose deception led to life.

Here Yaaqov's two lost sons (Yoseph and Shimon) are going to be restored through the disguised deception of Yoseph! But not before another layer of complications and testing.

Reuven's Inadequate Offer

In Genesis 37, Reuven proposed a plan to save Yoseph that did not work. Instead, it was the plan of his younger brother Yehudah that was accepted, and so Yoseph was sold as a slave. Now Reuven, the firstborn of Yaaqov, offers the lives of his own two sons in the place of Shimon and Binyamin. While this could appear noble, it does seem a bit misdirected. Instead of confessing his own treachery and betrayal, he offers up the lives of his innocent sons to die for his own sins.

Yaaqov refuses this offer, as it will only result in more death. It's better to cut his losses and move forward. This portrait of Reuven, as a failed firstborn, repeats his failure from Genesis 37 and opens the way for his younger brother Yehudah to propose an even more noble plan, which is precisely what's going to happen.

Binyamin, the New Yoseph

Notice how Yaaqov's response mirrors the response he gave when he was shown Yoseph's garment.

Genesis 42:38

And he said,
 "My son will not go down with y'all,
 because his brother is dead,
 and he alone is the remnant,
 and should disaster happen to him ... **you would make
 my gray-hair go down to the grave in grief ."**

Genesis 37:35

And all his sons and all his daughters got
 up to comfort him,
 and he refused to be comforted,
 and he said, "Surely, **I will go down to my
 son, grieving, to the grave !"**
 And his father wept for him.

Grieving in Genesis 42 and Genesis 37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Brothers Take a Second Trip to Egypt

Genesis 43:1-15

43:1-5

Ya'akov & Yehudah Debate About Going Down to Egypt; Without Binyamin, They Cannot Return

- **43:3** "[Yoseph] swore an oath (העֵד הָעֵד) that we can't see him with our brother"
- **43:5** "If you do not send him, we cannot go down"

43:6-7

Ya'akov & The Brothers Debate About Yoseph's Demand to See Binyamin

43:8-15

Yehudah and **Ya'akov** Debate Going Down to Egypt With Binyamin

- **43:8** "Send the young boy (נער) with me!"
- **43:9a** Yehudah swears to offers his life as a **substitute pledge (ערב)** in place of Binyamin
- **43:9b** "If I do not return [Binyamin] to you, it will be my sin against you all my days"

Genesis 43:15-44:13

43:15-25

The Brothers Go Down to Egypt, Return the Silver, and Are Brought Into Yoseph's House For A Meal

- 43:16 Yoseph said to the one over his house, "Bring the men inside"
- 43:21-22 "We brought the [extra] silver in our hands ... we don't know who put it in our bags!"

43:26-34

Yoseph Seats the Brothers for a Meal, Treating Binyamin With More Favor Than the Brothers

44:1-13

The Brothers Are Sent Back to Canaan, Binyamin Is Caught With the Silver Divination Cup

- 44:1-2 Yoseph said to the one over his house, "Put silver in each man's bag ... and put my silver cup in the bag of the little one"
- 44:8 "Look, we found silver in our bags and we returned it to you!"

Genesis 44:14-34

44:14

Yehudah & Brothers Return to Yoseph and Fall Down Before Him

44:15-17

Yoseph & Yehudah Discuss About the Stolen Silver Divination Cup

44:18-34

Yehudah's Speech Before Yoseph

- Yehudah retells the events of 43:1-15:
 - 44:33 "Let the young boy (נער) return back up with his brothers!"
 - 44:32-34 He offers his own life as a substitute pledge (ערב) in place of Binyamin and his father
 - 44:32 "If I do not return [Binyamin] to you, it will be my sin against my father for all my days"

Genesis 43:1-44:34. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This large section is the center of the center of the story of Yoseph and his brothers. It consists of three larger units (Gen. 43:1-15, 43:15-44:13, and 44:14-34) designed as a symmetry.

- The outer sections highlight a transformed Yehudah, who sees that their entire family is going to die if Yaaqov won't surrender the life of Binyamin. He is compelled to do the opposite of what he did to Yoseph in Genesis 37, and he offers his own life in the place of Yoseph's brother.

- The inner section focuses on the climactic additional test that Yoseph forces the brothers to undergo. With Binyamin now in Egypt, Yoseph can test their integrity even more precisely: he will create a scenario where they are forced to choose between Binyamin and a load of silver, just they did in Genesis 37.
- This three-part section brings all the themes and conflict between Yoseph and his brothers to a climax, as the brothers' evil comes full circle upon them.

It is also important to notice that Genesis 43-45 replays the main movements of the preceding Genesis 42. However, each step of the narrative in Genesis 42 is developed in greater detail and drama by its parallel in Genesis 43-45. In this way, the story feels like an intensified replay that forces the drama to its finish.

Genesis 42	Plot Elements	Genesis 43-45
Gen. 42:1-4	Yaaqov sends his sons to Egypt to buy grain (שֶׁבֶר) and get food.	Gen. 43:1-14
Gen. 42:5	Arrival in Egypt	Gen. 43:15-25
Gen. 42:6-16	First audience with Yoseph	Gen. 43:26-34
Gen. 42:17	Brothers in custody	Gen. 44:1-13
Gen. 42:25	Departure from Egypt with money secretly returned in the bags	Gen. 44:1
Gen. 42:18-24	Second audience with Yoseph	Gen. 44:14-45:15
Gen. 42:25-28	Departure from Egypt	Gen. 45:16-24
Gen. 42:29-38	Sons report to Yaaqov	Gen. 45:25-28
<i>Plot Elements of Genesis 42-45. Adapted from Godon J. Wenham, Genesis 16-50, 419.</i>		

Reflection Question

How are tragic characters in the Bible valuable for modern readers?